

It cannot be assumed even for a moment that L.K. Advani, A.B. Vajpayee or M.M. Joshi did not know the designs of the Sangh Parivar. These leaders were deemed and used by the Parivar as the publicly acceptable faces of the Parivar... These pseudo moderates were a tool in the hands of the RSS and stood to inherit the political successes engineered by the BJP.

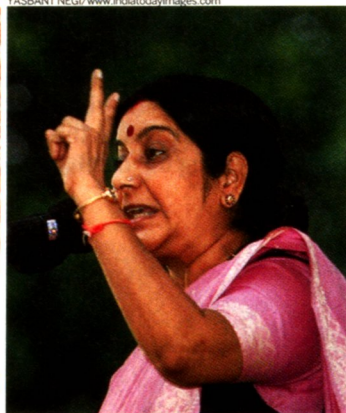
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THOUGH THE INITIAL REACTIONS OF THE VHP'S TOGADIA, RSS'S MADHAV AND BJP'S SWARAJ WERE IN TANDEM, THE UPA GOVERNMENT WILL ENSURE THAT THE ISSUE DOES NOT STAY IN THE NEWS FOR LONG

rake up the ghost of Babri during the debate in Parliament to vilify the BJP and paint itself as the messiah of the minorities. Ironically, this move may just boomerang and work to unite the BJP leadership firmly on the road to hardline Hindutva.

by Priya Sahgal

Family REUNION

The synergy in the reactions of Sangh Parivar constituents to the Liberhan challenge is reminiscent of their calibrated responses at the height of the Ram temple agitation. While the BJP leaders point to the factual loopholes in the report, the VHP retains what it considers is the ideological high ground and expressed a sense of pride in the demolition. The RSS plays the polite big brother, referring to the demolition as a development, not planned, but in keeping with the aspirations of the people.

At a time when the Sangh Parivar, particularly the BJP, is falling apart, such synergy between its members is like glue provided by Justice M.S. Liberhan. Says Sushma Swaraj: "The report is absolutely politically motivated. The roping in of Vajpayeeji by Justice Liberhan and the many factual loopholes in the report more than prove it." In what looked like a bold attempt to inspire the Hindutva brigades, VHP General Secretary Pravin Togadia thundered: "We are proud of what happened on December 6, 1992. We will build the Ram temple on the same spot and will not allow any other structure to come up." The RSS took a mature, parently view. Said its Spokesman Ram Madhav: "Though unexpected and unplanned by the Sangh Parivar, the demolition represented the aspirations of the people. It was like one uncontrollable wave that came and went." Within the BJP, leaders with a VHP or Bajrang Dal lineage were

unrestrained and direct. Says Vinay Katiyar, former Bajrang Dal chief: "I will not speak on it again and again. I have always said I take pride in the mosque demolition."

Sources say the response was precisely calibrated and the diktat went on to various Parivar outfits, including senior BJP leaders, soon after the leak of the Liberhan report. Family differences apart, the diktat was followed. Like an RSS leader put it: "On this issue, the Sangh Parivar leaders did what the RSS leadership wanted them to do. It was very heartening for the top RSS leadership."

But will the smile on the RSS leaders' faces last? Can the Liberhan Commission report galvanise the Sangh Parivar leadership? Will it be a political adhesive for the divided BJP, now at a political crossroads and looking for a leader to keep it afloat? Will it, at least for the time being, contain the ongoing battles within the Sangh Parivar—Arun Jaitley Vs Rajnath Singh and Sushma Swaraj, RSS Vs L.K. Advani, Arun Shourie Vs Jaitley and Rajnath Singh? Can it lead to rejuvenation of the Hindutva?

No one harbours the illusion that one report can put the Sangh Parivar back on track. As one BJP leader put it: "This report will keep the political turf hot for just one week. It will have little or absolutely no impact on the strained equations among Sangh Parivar leaders. It might not even impact the departure of Advani or the taking over by the new president. But it has certainly helped in a small way by boosting the morale of the Parivar worker, who was disgusted with its defensive posture on the demolition." Top leaders say that the report can't even bridge the serious ideological and personal differences between some of the leaders within the RSS and, therefore, is far from being the glue that can hold the Sangh Parivar together. The Congress-led Government at the Centre too has played its cards well with absolute inaction against any of the Parivar members, thereby reducing the political shelf life of the issue. by Uday Mahurkar